

Learning and Development Policy

Policy code: POL-HR-035. Owner: People Team (Learning and Development). Effective date: 1 October 2024. Applies to: all permanent and fixed-term employees at Leeds, Rotterdam, Austin and Penang.

1. Purpose

Meridian Instruments builds precision sensing equipment, and the quality of our Halcyon, Tessera and Lumen products depends on the skills of the people who design, build, sell and support them. This policy explains how employees can access funded training, how requests are approved, how study leave works and when course fees must be repaid if an employee leaves shortly after completing funded study.

2. Principles

- Development is a shared responsibility. Employees are expected to identify their own development needs and discuss them with their line manager at least twice a year, normally alongside the mid-year and year-end performance conversations.
- Training should link to the employee's current role, a planned next role, or a capability the business needs.
- We prefer the most cost-effective route that meets the need: internal courses, mentoring and on-the-job learning are considered before external spend.
- Mandatory compliance training (for example the Code of Conduct and Data Protection modules) is funded centrally and does not count against individual budgets.

3. Individual training budget

Every employee has an indicative individual training budget each fiscal year (1 April to 31 March). The budget is held in the employee's home cost centre and is not transferable between years.

Site | Currency | Annual individual budget

Leeds (UK) | GBP | £1,200

Rotterdam (NL) | EUR | €1,400

Austin (US) | USD | \$1,500

Penang (MY) | MYR | RM 4,000

The budget covers course fees, examination fees, conference registration and learning materials. Travel and accommodation for training are claimed under the Travel and Expense Policy (POL-FIN-007) and are charged to the same cost centre, but do not count against the individual budget.

Unused budget does not carry over and cannot be paid out.

4. Requesting training

All external training must be requested in advance using form F-260 Training Request, submitted in Keel at Keel > Learning > Training Request. Requests should be raised at least four weeks before the booking deadline for the course.

A complete request includes:

- the course or qualification title and provider;
- dates, format (in person, virtual or blended) and location;
- the total cost, including any examination fees;

- how the training relates to the employee's role or development plan;
- whether the employee is asking for study leave.

5. Approval

Approval depends on the cost of the request compared with the individual budget.

Request value | Approver

Within the individual budget | Line manager

Above the individual budget | Head of Department plus L&D

Requests above the individual budget are routed automatically in Keel to the Head of Department and then to the Learning and Development team, who can be contacted at learning@meridian-instruments.example. L&D checks whether a group programme or internal alternative already exists and may negotiate with the provider.

Once approved, courses are booked by L&D or paid through the normal purchasing route. Employees should not pay course fees personally and claim them back unless L&D has agreed this in writing.

6. Professional qualifications

Meridian supports multi-year professional qualifications that are relevant to the role, such as chartered engineering, accountancy, HR and procurement qualifications. These are approved on a module-by-module or year-by-year basis, and each year's cost is assessed against the approval thresholds in section 5.

Where Meridian pays for a professional qualification, the employee must sign form F-265 Study Support and Fee Repayment Agreement before the first payment is made. L&D sends F-265 through Keel once the F-260 request has been approved.

7. Study leave

Employees studying for an approved professional qualification are entitled to:

- up to 5 days of paid study leave per year; and
- paid leave for the day of each examination sitting.

Study leave is requested in Keel at Keel > Time Off > Request Leave using the leave type "Study Leave", and should be booked at least two weeks in advance. Study leave that is not used in the fiscal year lapses. Resits are supported once; further resits are at the employee's own cost unless the Head of Department agrees otherwise.

8. Repayment of fees

Under the F-265 agreement, if the employee resigns or is dismissed for misconduct after Meridian has funded a qualification or a single course costing more than the individual budget, the employee repays a proportion of the fees:

Leaving date | Repayment

Within 12 months of completion | 100% of fees

Within 24 months of completion | 50% of fees

After 24 months | Nothing

Repayment is deducted from final pay where local law allows, or invoiced otherwise. Repayment is not required where the employee is made redundant or leaves because of ill health.

Completion means the date of the final examination or the course end date, whichever is later.

9. Conferences and events

Attendance at external conferences is treated as training and requires an F-260 request. Where an employee is presenting on behalf of Meridian, the presentation must be reviewed in advance by the relevant product line leader, and any material about Tessera or Lumen roadmaps must be cleared by the CTO's office.

10. Records

Keel records all approved training, completion dates and certificates. Employees should upload certificates at Keel > Learning > My Learning within 30 days of completion so that qualifications appear on their profile.

11. Related documents

- Travel and Expense Policy (POL-FIN-007)
- Employee Handbook (HBK-HR-001)
- Cost Centre Directory

Questions about this policy should be sent to learning@meridian-instruments.example.